Singularity: The Point of No Return

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Light Hope/Mara (She-Ra)

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Singularity: The Point of No Return

by Tempest_Wind

Summary

Mara's hopes, her dreams, her promise led her on the path to becoming Etheria's First Champion. Her courage paved the way for Adora and her friends to change the world. Her sacrifice made their victory tangible. This is her story.

Part 4 of this series focuses on betrayal, revelations, transformation, and the truth behind Mara's mission.

This is a prequel story revolving around Mara, the Grayskull Squadron, the origins of the First Ones. This will contain spoilers for the first four seasons of She-Ra. Chapters include links to research done on the original He-Man and She-Ra series.

Grief

Chapter Notes

This is part 4 in a series.

Read part 1 here: Entropy: All Stars Must Fade.

Read part 2 here: Quintessence: Change is Inevitable.

Read part 3 here: Umbra: All That Remains Hidden.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"I failed…" Mara murmured to herself. "He's dead…"

Deena sobbed, clutching Sorrowful's large serpentine head in her hands, and pressing her forehead to his muzzle.

"He was my friend… He was my *friend*," she sobbed and the Forest Elf's pain echoed as cracks that formed along icy stalagmites within the cavern.

Wrapped in the warm safety of She-Ra's form, Mara felt tears slide down her cheeks. Her one hope for her friends, her only way to save them and finish her mission, had just been destroyed.

"The last dragon… and this is how I meet you," the words escaped Mara's mouth as she reached up, resting a hand on the back of the great beast's head. There came a pull, a powerful connection that, just as quickly, frayed and fell apart. It left an empty cavern within her as she yearned for the impossible.

"I never even got to hear your story…" Mara murmured as she tried to move her hand away. But She-Ra reached up within her and pressed her hand firmly to the deceased creature's forehead. "Wh… what are you…?" she began.

"Close your eyes. Concentrate," commanded that powerful voice within her.

What? What are we doing? Mara caught herself asking, silently fighting for control of her body.

She-Ra's voice and presence were firm, but not overwhelming.

"It doesn't have to end like this. This creature is part of Etheria, and his story doesn't end here."

Mara felt white-hot magic cycling through her, but this time it didn't burn, didn't tear at her flesh. She felt warmth and comfort rise like tides that intertwined with this raw power.

"Trust in me," that voice commanded.

I trust you, Mara replied and closed her eyes.

Deena watched with wide eyes as golden light blanketed She-Ra and the body of Sorrowful.

Pulses of power moved like electricity through the dragon's carcass, erasing scars and bleaching his body the color of freshly-fallen snow. The rows of fins along his back shimmered an iridescent hue, reflecting every color of the rainbow while bathed in the light of She-Ra's magic.

The great beast's eyes blinked slowly open as he stared down the legendary princess.

"You have restored me, connected me with memories I once wished to be rid of," the creature's voice echoed as a roar within the cavern, which turned quickly into words within the minds of his two companions.

"I remember now, all of it. My name is Granamyr, and I am the lone survivor of the destruction of my people." his deep voice resonated within Mara, as that connection reformed between them and hummed to life.

"Granamyr…" Mara began even before she fully understood. "I'm so sorry…"

"My kind were born to guard the power at the heart of Etheria," Granamyr went on, his jaw moving faintly as the words appeared in Mara and Deena's minds.

"What sort of magic lies at the heart of Etheria?" Mara asked.

"Oooooh! Ooooh! I know!" Deena waved her hands wildly, a grin spreading on her face. "The power is unborn!"

Granamyr's fierce gaze softened at the sight of Deena. *"You listened well to my tales, old friend,"* he purred. *"The power of potential lies at the heart of Etheria. In its raw form, it serves as the lifeblood of the magic of the planet. It created the forests and the oceans, the people and the animals, and it is the source of our magic. It allows for miracles and for destruction.*"

The cave grew darker at his last word. *"My people were born to guard this raw power so that it couldn't fall into destructive hands. But we allowed ourselves to think our magic made us untouchable, undefeatable, and superior to others. When the Lizardfolk came to battle for our land, my people were not prepared for their destructive force… nor their powerful weapons."*

Mara's eyes widened at this revelation as she slowly connected the dragon's words to recent memories.

A skeleton in the shape of a ship sat on the sea, its wood arched like a barren rib cage, orange-red flames engulfing it in a devastating aura.

"Pirates used to be explorers, but lately…" Sparkle said.

"You got yourselves some cool new toys in response," Shay said.

"You're guaranteeing devastation and death!" Serenia snapped.

"SO BE IT!" Princess Glacia hollered. "Better mutually assured destruction than giving in quietly. Death before dishonor!"

"They leave no survivors, so none can tell their tale," Sparkle's voice began to fade.

Dread bubbled up within Mara and she clutched her hand over her mouth.

"The Crimson Oasis is at the center of this arms race…" she muttered as chills prickled along her skin.

Chapter End Notes

Haven't done one of these in a while:

Here is the original series inspiration for Deena, Sorrowful the Dragon, and Granamyr, as well as inspiration for the plot of the genocide against dragons. Deena in the original series was just a human girl who was friends with the cowardly dragon Sorrowful. When rewriting and updating the plot, it became clear to me that Sorrowful was going to be the dragon's chosen name, and that I wanted to rewrite Deena as a fae equivalent. I translated "coward" into an actual act that isn't cowardly but would cause a lot of self-blame: fleeing the murder of his people to live somewhere untouchable. In that case, he would want his acts of "cowardice" erased from his mind, and Deena, who eats memories, would be only too gleeful to oblige. I chose Granamyr as his true identity because of the war Granamyr participated in. But instead of humans versus dragons, and in the spirit of limiting as many human characters as possible, I chose to make it a battle with the Lizardfolk. There are more parallels between plots coming up soon, so I hope you enjoy!

Deena: https://he-man.fandom.com/wiki/Deena

Sorrowful: https://he-man.fandom.com/wiki/Sorrowful

Granamyr: https://he-man.fandom.com/wiki/Granamyr

Gravity

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Weapons… What kinds of weapons?” Mara asked, her voice hushed. “How did they create weapons powerful enough to kill a dragon?”

”I know not,” Granamyr said. *”The Lizardfolk had no land to call their own, no access to technology this destructive. They acquired it from sympathizers, elsewhere. But I can assure you, these weapons existed in contrast to all that is Etherian.”*

"Contrary to Etheria? Wh… what does that…?"

"These weapons were the antithesis of magic," he said as Deena hugged her own arms and grimaced. *"They pulled out the magic from within our souls, and left nothing but scraps and bones behind."*

“And now they control your kingdom, don’t they? The Kingdom of the Crimson Oasis?”

”The Oasis… My people were born the guardians of that fountain of magic for generations, long before time recorded,” Granamyr said. *”To think how the people who killed off my kind are misusing that magic… While I wasted away here for fifty years…”*

“Why did you hide away here? Surely one of the other kingdoms could have tried to help, and this valley is dangerous…” Mara began.

“He came to forget!” Deena said with a grin. “This is the ooooonly place on Etheria where he could forget all the bad stuff.”

”People do not simply arrive at the Valley of the Lost by accident, Granamyr said. *”They must have a wish in their heart to come*

here. Mine was… to lose touch with every memory that caused me pain."

Mara stared at Deena with creeping discomfort. "But Deena stole your memories… fed off of them. It… it killed you!"

"As a forest elf, she doesn't know any other way," he said. *"And I gave those memories unto her, willingly, the entire time."* Granamyr squinted his enormous eyes as he regarded Mara and she felt the strands of their connection grow heavy for a moment. *"You did the same thing, didn't you? I see it in her memories: the one you call She-Ra."*

A chill ran through her and Mara felt an intense emotion flare within her. It didn't come from her, but it was directed at her, this resentment and, worse still, disappointment that came from the entity known as She-Ra.

"I-I…" Mara began, feeling her own guilt surge alongside that fiery emotion.

"It is a temptation, to forget," Granamyr said. *"But without memories, we lose touch with ourselves… our desires, our motivations. It's tempting to forget, but each time we do, another part of us dies until there is nothing left. Be grateful to your guardian that she fought so hard to preserve you."*

"I-I am…" Mara murmured, biting her lip. "I'm just ashamed that I wasn't strong enough to fight it."

"Actively fighting doesn't ensure victory each time," Granamyr said. *"Upon regaining yourself, you could have run. You could have left here and pretended this place was a nightmare. Instead, you followed through on your mission."*

"B-but does it really count if I didn't do that alone?" Mara asked.

"Sometimes having company makes all the difference," Granamyr said, meeting Deena's gaze with a soft smile. *"I would have disappeared far sooner if not for visits from you, my friend,"* he

said. *"Each time you asked me to think of another story for you, I held on just a little longer."*

Granamyr shifted onto reptilian feet, filling the cave with his presence.

"And now I must atone for my cowardice," he said. *"Climb onto my back, Mara. We shall free your friends and make the lizard kingdom answer for their crimes."*

Taking in the breadth of his enormous, serpentine body, Mara felt a clenching in her gut as she imagined herself falling off his back onto the rough ground below.

"Oh, eheheh I, uh, think I can walk," Mara offered.

The dragon squinted at her. *"We're going to be flying,"* he informed her.

Now Mara pictured herself free-falling through the sky.

"Wait, are you *serious*?" her voice cracked, but Granamyr was already focused on Deena, his hardened expression softening as he took in the presence of the forest elf.

"*I will return to you one day, old friend,*" he murmured to her, *"with stories of triumph."*

Deena's smile creased the edges of her eyes. "I've always wanted to hear a happy story from you," she said, her tone sweet, yet sincere.

There was no graceful way to climb onto the dragon's enormous back, Mara found as she slid down his scales for the fourth time. Swiping at a spiked ridge from his back, she haphazardly clung to it, and then flattened herself against him for good measure.

"O-okay, I think I'm ready…" she said, doubting her own words as they exited her mouth.

"*Then we are off!*" Granamyr announced, a ragged roar escaping his throat as he erratically galloped out of the cave, before leaping into the air.

As Mara held close to his broad back, she found the sensation not unlike jumping into the pool. She felt suspended in the air, waiting for the impact, only for it to never come. He tore through the sky like a fish in water, riding the wind thermals with a natural ease.

The grace and fluidity of the movement made Mara more aware of how awkward the action of walking felt in comparison: one foot pressing into the ground before the next, barely suspending an unwieldy body on too-thin appendages.

This, flying, felt the antithesis of it. Wind rose to cup them from below, carrying their movements, as it tickled Mara's hair free from its tight braid. The thrill of it felt like freedom and for a moment, Mara felt completely right, in a way no place ever made her feel before.

Chapter End Notes

> Hey, I'm sorry for the long delay. 3 weeks ago I started a new job as a freelance writer full-time and I don't have as much mental capacity to write professionally and for fun every day. I promise to try to keep up every two weeks.
>
> Thank you all for your patience and thank you SO MUCH for the comments. They really keep me going.
>
> I estimate this story of have 100 chapters total, and we are beginning the approach to the climax. I'm really excited for you all to see what next lands Mara and company get to explore next.

Guilty

Chapter Summary

> Ooookay so these chapters are obviously taking me a lot longer than expected. This particular chapter gave me a lot of grief and was extremely hard to write. I think once I get the next chapter done, I'll be able to write more regularly again, but this time I'm not making any promises other than that I plan to finish this story within 100 chapters.

Granymyr slithered through the sky, riding the thermals as the wind swept back Mara's loosened hair. From this vantage point, every detail about Etheria seemed so tiny and fragile. The frost-covered mountains huddled together as if for warmth. Above, the pillars rising from Arxia's floating citadel were clear within sight for the first time since Mara and her team landed. The sandy desert of the Kingdom of Scorpion Hill looked pearly-white by the light of the moons.

And as they reached the Growling Sea's edge, the desert was broken up by patches of greenery. A sprawling kingdom, reflecting like gold in the midday moonlight, stretched around the freshwater lake like a resting beast, the tropical trees waving around it as if in greeting. People in the form of tiny specks always moved between the miniature ships and the lengthy castle.

"How their garish designs have distorted the home of my brothers and sisters," Granymyr snorted. *"This used to be protected land, kept from the eyes and hands of those who would misuse its power. Now they've made it a public spectacle."*

Mara felt a drop in her stomach as Granymyr shifted downwards, diving towards the tallest point of the rounded castle. He filled his lungs, the air roaring against his muzzle as he dove, and the wind whipped away Mara's words as she tried to ask what was happening.

A beam of light shot out from his mouth, tearing into the structure below. The ant-like people, that were growing ever-larger with Granymyr's descent, ran in chaotic disorder as they desperately attempted to flee.

He landed on the rooftop with a savage roar that caused the last of the crowds to disperse.

"Granymyr, wait!" Mara cried, finding her voice once more.

Two dozen guards lined either side of the ruined castle that Granymyr stood atop, firing weapons that shot a sickly greenish light at the dragon. He howled, recoiling at first as Mara screamed, clinging tight to the scales along his back. However the lasers glanced harmlessly off his outer skin.

Granymyr parted his mouth to launch another attack.

"Wait! Granymyry, wait! Killing them won't fix this!" Mara cried.

His growl turned to dark laughter and he bared his teeth as if in a grin, leaning closer towards the lizardfolk guards who continued to rain harmless light on his form.

"BRING ME YOUR PRINCESS. THE ONE WHO DESTROYED MY PEOPLE AND DEBASED MY HOMELAND," he roared.

No guard moved a muscle. In response, Granymyr gasped in another breath of air and shot a ball of energy at the next nearest building. Glass and marble exploded out from the structure.

There was calamity as several of the guards left their posts, rushing inside the destroyed castle that Granymyr roosted on. The dragon let out a threatening purr as he settled his long body over the broken structure.

Mara shifted to her feet on his back, climbing her way along the iridescent dorsal fin as she moved closer to his face, trying to meet his gaze.

“Granamyr, what are you planning to do?” she asked, her voice hushed as she approached his enormous ear.

”I will have my revenge,” he said simply as guards led the figure of Princess Chamelea out. The princess rested her hands on her hips and opened her mouth to give orders, but fell silent at the sight of the colossal dragon stretching his body across the rooftops like a sun-bathing cat.

With a grunt, one of Granamry’s many arms reached down and scooped up Chamelea in its hold, raising her to his eye level. She squeaked and let out a pitiful growl as she fretted and squirmed in his hold.

”You… you are not the one who destroyed my people,” rumbled Granamyr.

Chamelea squeezed her eyes shut and shook her head rapidly, beads of sweat sliding down her scaly skin. She parted her lips on a rumbling growl, but through She-Ra’s connection with Granamyr, Mara understood every word.

”N-no! It was my grandmother: Salamanda,” Chamelea insisted, bowing her head as she spoke, the tip of her tail flicking around beneath Granamyr’s hold.

The dragon narrowed his gaze on her, snorting out a puff of smoke that made Chamelea cough and gag.

”You are nothing like the fierce and conniving princess your grandmother was,” Granamyr insisted.

”That’s true! That’s true!” Chamelea insisted, nodding.

”And you’re barely half as smart as her,” Granamyr added.

Chamelea opened her mouth to reply, then thought better of it. Instead, she closed her mouth and nodded hard enough to shake the sweat off her face.

"But your grandmother wasn't that smart to begin with," Granamyr growled. *"Your people didn't develop those weapons on their own. Who gave you the tools to leech magic from my people, to leave them behind as empty carcasses?"*

"I-I-I don't know what you mean!" Chamelea insisted.

With a roar, Granamyr leapt off the castle rooftop and knocked over the nearest building. Wind magic whipped around them, as a tsunami of sand rose from the ground exposing an enormous dragon skeleton beneath.

"YOUR GRANDMOTHER BUILT HER KINGDOM ATOP THE BONES OF MY PEOPLE," Granamyr roared as Chamelea trembled in his grasp.

His gaze narrowed on her. ***"And now I shall do the same to yours,"*** he hissed.

Groundbreaking

Chapter Notes

GUESS WHO'S BACK.

As Granamyr parted his mouth, preparing another beam of destructive light, Chamelea trembled in his hold, her head swiveling wildly as she searched for an escape.

"Granamyr, **wait**!" Mara cried and felt her own words thrum with power through the connection between them. A second, more forceful voice added itself to her own as She-Ra's ties to the dragon halted his movements.

He parted his lips around pointed teeth and sneered at Mara. "*You dare hold me back from my revenge?*" he hissed.

"This isn't revenge," she said. "Salamanda is the one you want, not Chamelea."

"*She's right! She's right!*" Chamelea insisted, nodding fervently and pointing at Mara with the tip of her tail. "*Grandmother died years before I was born! Sooooo you can just let me go--*"

Mara narrowed her gaze on the cowardly princess as Granamyr tightened his hold on Chamelea, squeezing a puff of air out of her as her skin turned visibly blue, before shifting to a purplish hue.

"*No matter,*" Granamyr growled, offering Chamelea a sickening grin. "*Then I'll enact my revenge on her progeny.*" Chamelea let out a squeak of horror and turned literally white.

"That isn't revenge anymore," Mara insisted. "That's just creating a cycle of death and destruction. Someone will come to get revenge on you for killing a princess who never met a dragon until today."

"*Yesyesyesyesyes!*" Chamelea insisted, turning yellow, then green. "*Your shiny friend is very smart. So smart, your… um… dragon-ness.*"

Mara cupped both sides of her head and then gestured emphatically at Chamelea. "Stop AGREEING with me like that!" she insisted. "It's not helping!"

"*Your kindness and wisdom know no bounds,*" Chamelea continued, wiggling her legs and tail emphatically.

"Ugh, this coming from the same person who locked my friends in the dungeon…" Mara muttered.

Granamyr raised his vast head, his eyebrow twitching. "*This weakling imprisoned your friends?*"

Mara gave an involuntary wince. "She was a lot more intimidating at the time, okay?" she muttered between gritted teeth.

The enormous dragon let out a cough that shifted into open laughter. Chamelea, uncertain and desperate for acceptance, laughed along with him. Mara's gaze darted between them and as she receded into herself, she tried to get She-Ra's input about what was happening. The emotion She-Ra responded with was equally confused.

The laughter ended abruptly as Granamyr raised his snout towards the cowardly princess and narrowed his gaze at her.

"*You're going to release all of your prisoners,* he said.

"*Yes, yes, of course, of course, of course!*" Chamelea responded.

"*You're going to tell us everything you know about the weapons your grandmother used,*" he went on.

"*Yes, absolutely, yes,*" she insisted.

"*And then I **may** let you live.*"

Chamelea froze. "*A-ah…that's it?*" she struggled soon after to save face. "*Y-yes of course, thank you!*"

Granamyr slinked slowly off the top of the castle, helping Mara down onto the sand before dropping Chamelea unceremoniously. The moment the Lizardfolk princess' feet hit the ground, she scrambled to run away, feet sliding awkwardly against the sand.

She got barely a few steps away before Granamyr grabbed her by the scruff and pointed her in the direction of the castle.

"*This way…*" his voice came out as a low growl and she whimpered before nodding. Mara moved to follow after the princess, her gaze lingering on Granamyr.

"*Do not worry, Mara: I will be watching,*" he said.

She nodded, assuming that he was going to use some sort of all-seeing magic to keep guard over her. She stepped into the cool interior of the castle and, at once, the walls began to shake. Chamelea let out a squawk of worry, hugging her arms and shriveling in on herself as her gaze darted about. Mara raised her sword over Chamelea's head to defend her.

The stone walls cracked and broke before the roof was lifted off overhead. Mara gawked at Granamyr above, who wore a satisfied smirk on his serpentine face.

"*This* is what you meant by watching me?" Mara squeaked.

"*My castle!*" Chamelea cried, making grabby hands at the shattered remains of the roof.

"*It was the most… practical approach,*" Granamyr conceded.

Grit

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"My castle," Princess Chamelea shouted again, shaking her fists in the direction where the roof used to be, now replaced with the watchful gaze of an ancient dragon. An enormous eye blinked down at her and her neck disappeared into her shoulders as the princess turned forest green.

"This way," Chamelea curled her lip before gesturing reproachfully for Mara to follow. They passed the throne room where Chamelea passed judgment and sent Mara alone into a seemingly unwinnable situation with only cryptic guidance. By the throne, Mara caught sight of what was unmistakably Lev's scooter. It looked beat-up, used and abused while under the "care" of the princess.

They moved down a narrow corridor that arced with a narrow incline, the air around them growing cooler the deeper they went. Mara transformed her sword into a lantern and glanced towards Granamyr, making sure she was still within sight of him.

They moved through a broad set of wooden doors into an enclosed chamber of sand, rock, and metal bars, away from the dragon's watchful eye. As the doors fell shut behind them, Princess Chamelea whirled on Mara, growling in the back of her throat.

"*GUARDS!*" she roared and half a dozen armed guards rushed from their stations, their guns pointed towards Mara.

"*You thought you could march into my land, with the criminal dragon that was supposed to be brought to justice, and take everything away from me?* Chamelea hissed, yanking the gun out of a guard's hand and pointing it at Mara's head.

Mara froze, her hand gripping the lantern as she watched it work against her will to transform back into a sword.

No, please, I don't know how to fight, Mara insisted within her own mind.

"Chamelea isn't giving you a choice," came She-Ra's powerful voice. *"You're not a fighter, but you are strong. Entrust yourself to me and you will be safe."*

Time seemed to slow as Chamelea's finger closed on the trigger, tugging it as a streak of green light inched its way out. Mara's instinct was to cover her face, to duck down, to run and hide. Against every screaming nerve of her body, she forced herself to let go.

The Sword of Protection cut in the way of the beam,and the laser beam ricocheted the glowing edge of her sword, striking the sand by Chamelea's feet. For a panicked moment the lizardfolk princess lost her composure, stomping and flailing her arms.

"*GET HER!*" Chamelea shrieked to her guards as a furious roar sounded from overhead. As the guards charged She-Ra, Mara felt her legs turn and sprint towards the wide cells as the stone walls and ceiling began to tremble.

Doubt flickered through Mara's mind as she turned her back towards the cells, aware that she had just cornered herself. Mara's fear overwhelmed her bravery with every shaking breath.

"I can't do this alone," the panicked words escaped her tight throat.

"Mara!" amidst the chaos, she heard the cries of her team from inside the cell. Her heart tightened within her chest as a sense of hope lit within her.

"Good thing I'm not alone," she said aloud to herself as a smirk slipped out across her lips. She-Ra guided her sword to the lock

on the cell. With a whip-like motion, the Sword of Protection severed the lock in half and the cell door swung open.

Serenia and Romeo were the first ones out, diving for the nearest guards and seizing hold of their weapons. Gideon charged out, hollering a strange war cry as the redhead tugged another guard into a bear hug. Shay and Nessa both lingered behind with Lev, helping him upright as they watched the situation unfold.

The prisoners in the other cells saw the ensuing chaos, which filled them with hope for the first time in years. Their cries sounded from around the room but were indecipherable as sand and rock poured down from the ceiling.

Larger stone collapsed from the pillars as Granamyr dug his claws into the ceiling's surface, his agitated growl rumbling with the shifting earth. Guided by She-Ra, Mara slashed the next lock on the next cell. The dozen prisoners inside rushed to their feet, confusion and anger at their captors twisting their faces to a snarl.

"Keep close to the walls to avoid falling rocks!" she shouted to them, her voice sounding more commanding than it ever had before. But the prisoners were eager to join in the fight, and several rushed at the guards, to assist the Greyskull Squadron.

Their determination and direction matching step-for-step, She-Ra guided Mara deeper into the prison. And as the rubble fell around her, Mara was once more in that cave, clutching the broken robot K.O.W.L. close as she dove from pillar to pillar.

But instead of struggling, slipping, and watching her own life dangle from a thread, Mara felt She-Ra's power gently pull her away from falling rocks, lift her over unsteady rubble, and tug her by the hand towards the last sets of cells.

With She-Ra's power, she felt a natural sense of certainty and confidence in every action. Striking the final two locks, she cautioned the prisoners about falling rocks. As soon as the thought came to protect these people, She-Ra's force turned the

Sword of Protection into an enormous shield, which she held over them as they huddled under the only part of the prison that still had some structure to it.

Granamyr's enormous fist pushed through the stone and he grabbed the scrambling Princess Chamelea.

"*You wretched, dishonest person,*" he growled at her as the shaking earth slowed to stillness.

"*WE SURRENDER!*" Chamelea shrieked, waving her arms above her head. Most of her guards dropped their weapons to raise their hands as well, and Serenia and Romeo stopped fighting.

"Yoink," Shay said as they tugged the gun free of the guard that was still being held in place by Gideon.

Chapter End Notes

This took a few drafts to get right, so sorry for the delay!

Originally there wasn't even a fight scene and it was soooo boring. Finally I got hit with inspiration after I tried working with the bad drafts for a while.

Guidance

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Granamyr lifted the struggling Chamelea high into the air, and slithered away. Mara stood rooted to the spot as she felt both the urge to fight and the spirit of She-Ra slip away. Exhaustion, relief, and all the pent-up fear filled the gap that remained behind until her head became too heavy to lift.

When her gaze fell to the ground, there came a firm grasp around her wrist, followed by a tug. Mara looked up to meet the eyes of Serenia, whose expressions shifted between pinched worry and pained gratitude, telling Mara that she wasn't alone.

"Come on, we can't let your new friend get too far ahead of us," Serenia insisted, pulling Mara along, as the rest of her team and the freed prisoners followed after.

"Was that really a DRAGON?" Gideon's voice came out about an octave higher than usual as the Greyskull Squadron, Romeo, and the prisoners rushed down the hall. The grin on his face shone beyond the lines of weariness and exhaustion as he carried an equally confused Lev on his shoulders.

"Yeah," Mara admitted with a laugh, barely audibly.

"I can't believe that," Lev insisted. "N-no way."

"We all saw it," Nessa insisted. "That was a dragon."

"The last dragon," Romeo murmured, his voice barely audible.

"Eh, I thought he'd be taller," Shay insisted and Lev rolled his eyes while Nessa threw her arms down in frustration.

Laughter escaped from Mara's mouth for the first time in what felt like weeks, breaking free of the restraints of tension within her body. Her hand slipped back enough to entwine fingers with Serenia, who turned back to smile, a hint of pain amidst the warmth in her expression.

As they rounded the corner and entered the throne room, Lev let out a cry of "MY SCOOTER!" Mara stumbled to a stop as Gideon, Shay and Nessa peeled away towards the sand-laden mobility aid.

Serenia's hand tightened against hers and Mara met her gaze again.

"Come on," Serenia said. "Trust them to figure out the scooter and help the prisoners. We have to catch up with your dragon."

Running ahead with Romeo in tow, they reached the newly-abandoned open market, the splintered wood from various stalls and carts acting as a haphazard nest upon which Granamyr rested his enormous serpentine form.

"Granamyr!" Mara called out to him as she approached, and the fierce look in his eyes softened. Serenia hesitated, hovering behind Mara as her shoulders bunched around her neckline in the presence of this creature.

"You have taken on a new form," he said. *"It feels more gentle than your She-Ra form. It suits you."* He inclined his head towards Serenia and Romeo in greeting.

Mara's cheeks flushed red and Serenia looked between them with mounting confusion.

"Is… is the dragon saying something?" Serenia asked Mara, who felt the air leave her lungs as she met Granamyr's gaze.

"She can't hear us?" Mara asked.

"Every connection between a She-Ra and her steed is unique," Granamyr said. *"Mine allows me to translate the thoughts and*

feelings of myself and others directly into your mind."

"So it only works on me. A-and 'a She-Ra's steed'? What does that…?" Mara murmured aloud. "Wait, how much do you know about She-Ra?"

Romeo moved in closer. "What is he saying?"

The dragon's eyes squinted to smiling half-moons. *"I'll be happy to share it all with you,"* Granamyr said. *"But first, to deal with this intruder."* He raised the paw clutching Chamelea until she was level with his eyes.

"I-intruder? Y-y-you don't mean me, do you?" Chamelea squeaked. *"B-b-because from my point of view, you're really more the intruder…"* she trailed off as regret stole the confidence from her words. Then she tried laughing it off as a joke.

Granamyr's gaze narrowed on her in a silent threat. She went very still as if that might appease him.

"As the rightful guardian of Crimson Oasis, I hereby exile Princess Chamelea and her people from this land," Granamyr declared.

Silence fell over them as Chamelea's eyes widened.

"Y-you can't be serious!" she insisted, turning a grey-green shade. *"I'm connected to the runestone on this land!"*

"Yet you've abused that power using it only for vanity, and you've used the position for selfish gain and control over others," said Granamyr. *"You forget, princess, the dragons have been guarding this land since long before your ancestors connected to the runestone."*

"But…" Chamelea began, her voice hushed, *"This is the only home I've ever known. My people were nomadic until my grandmother…"*

Granamyr glared at her, and she stopped her sentence.

"Where will my people go?" she asked, her voice a low murmur.

Granamyr took a deep breath, letting it out slowly. *"That isn't my problem,"* he said, with a hint of pain in his voice before he lowered her to the ground.

Chamelea's gaze moved around the ruined marketplace, taking in the sight of destroyed stalls. The only people that remained were the enemies she'd made and a few weaponless guards.

"What did they say?" Serenia asked carefully.

"Granamyr is… he's letting them go," Mara said, the words heavy in her mouth. "But they have to leave this place and never come back."

Romeo's eyebrows rose at this. "The Lizardfolk kingdom has lost their port," he said, his words distant as though he was deep in thought.

Signaling her remaining guards, Chamelea straightened her posture. She cast one last look back, meeting Mara's gaze with a glare, before the Lizardfolk princess walked out into the desert.

Chapter End Notes

> Sadly, this arc comes to a close on a heavy note. Chamelea, while not a good person in the slightest, pays for the crimes of her grandmother, which were committed before she was born. And though Chamelea was a tyrant, her people now don't have a place to live anymore.

Grandstanding

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Are you sure you won’t need us to stay, to help you return all the prisoners home?” Mara asked Romeo as concern pinched together her brows. Her ship came for a landing behind her in what was once the marketplace as she kept her full attention on Romeo.

He smiled and shook his head. “That’s a generous offer, but I’ll get in contact with the Council and they’ll send people who have a little more… expertise in this particular field,” he said. Her face flushed and he let out a chuckle.

“Oh, jeeze, I guess we might uh…. mess that up,” Mara admitted, her gaze darting to the ground in unease. “Wouldn’t want to make a-an international incident or…”

“No, no, it’s not that,” he insisted, his tone growing warm. “What your team is doing for Etheria? Nobody else can do that job. So let’s have the experts work in their particular fields, yours included, okay?”

Mara nodded, not quite believing his words, but appreciating them nonetheless. “Understood,” she said. “Do you need anything else?”

Romeo’s gaze lingered over towards Shay as the hacker walked by. “There is one thing,” he began. “Hey Shay?”

The hacker regarded him with a lazy look.

“Thanks for getting that weapon from the guard,” Romeo began. “I can bring it to the Council for further examination.”

“What weapon?” Shay asked.

Romeo blinked at them. "The… the one you have tucked under your arm," he said.

"Ohhhhhh, *this* weapon," Shay replied. "Nah, that's okay. I like the look of it. Think I'll keep it."

Romeo shifted through several confused expressions before blinking his way back into the conversation. "I-I wasn't asking… Give me the weapon, Shay," he said, reaching for the weapon.

"Uhhhhh no can do," Shay replied, moving back to evade Romeo's hands. "See, *I'm* the one with the weapon here. Soooo I don't think you get to be the one asking things of *me.*"

With that, Shay gave a lazy salute with the tip of the gun and walked backwards up the platform onto the ship.

"I…" Romeo struggled for words as Mara wore a look of blank horror on her face. "That is definitely insubordination."

"I am *so* sorry," Mara insisted. "I-I-I'll have a talk with them."

"Sometimes I forget none of you are military," Romeo said, amusement coloring his stone. "It would make some things easier, if you were. Certainly more obedient." He offered a smile that seemed reassuring on the surface, but the magic of She-Ra seemed to clench around Mara's heart.

"I… I suppose so," she murmured weakly.

"But, the wisdom of the Council is beyond any of us to question," Romeo went on. "The Greyskull Squadron is unique. But I've seen for myself how that makes you uniquely qualified for this mission."

Mara wanted to be flattered at the praise, but that tense feeling around her heart tightened. She nodded, looking back towards her ship as unease twitched across her face.

"You should get going," Romeo indicated with a nod of his head.

“Um… o-one thing,” she began. “The Lizardfolk. I… I know Chamelea is terrible. She was a tyrant, much like her grandmother.” Mara fidgeted with her hands as she spoke. “But… but if the Council can search the planet for land that isn’t already taken… then maybe… maybe the Lizardfolk could have a place to live.”

Romeo’s eyebrows rose. “She imprisoned your team, and me, and sent you to what was supposed to be your death,” he said.

“I-I know,” Mara insisted. “But… all the other Lizardfolk shouldn’t be punished for the decisions of their princess. A-and besides, I don’t think Chamelea would do it again. So… so please consider…”

“I’ll speak to the Council,” Romeo reassured her, and Mara let out a sigh she didn’t know she was holding.

“Thank you,” she said, moving towards the platform. “Oh, and Corporal Romeo?”

He looked up at her.

“Thank you for everything,” sincerity hung clearly in her tone. She then gave a clumsy salute.

Romeo looked stunned for a moment. Then he shrugged it off and gave her an awkward but genuine smile.

“Good luck on your mission, Mara,” he said and Mara wanted to believe that he meant those words.

Her gauntlet transformed into a sword and she raised it over her head. “For the honor of Greyskull!” she cried as the familiar magic engulfed her, surrounding her in comforting warmth.

She perched onto the nose of her ship before it carefully hovered, climbing slowly past the buildings as it lifted higher. Crouching down on top of her ship, Mara cupped her hands around her mouth.

“Granamyr!” she called to the dragon.

He dove beneath the clouds, circling the ship as he glided by on his back. Mara caught herself laughing at the sight of his serpentine form weaving effortlessly through the clouds.

“My team and I have to submit our report about this mission,” she said. “But I have so many questions for you.”

“*The answers that I have can wait however long you need,* Granamyr said. “*To summon me, you merely have to call for me. Our sacred bond will make it so I always hear you.*”

“Where will you be?” Mara asked.

“*Here, always, protecting my homeland and the Oasis,*” Granamyr said. “*I shall keep vigil from the skies, and prevent anyone else from claiming this land for themselves. My task is to protect this land, and I will finally fulfill my duties.*”

Mara nodded, her smile faltering. “Won’t it get lonely if it’s just you?” she asked.

“*You’ll have to stop by to tell me stories of your adventures,*” he said simply.

A grin tugged across her lips. “I promise,” she said.

“*With such wonderful company, I don’t expect I’ll ever be lonely again,”* he said, his lips pulling back on a smile as a rumble rather like a purr issued from his massive form.

Chapter End Notes



Gauge

As the ship hovered mid-air, Mara slid open the door and climbed inside, shedding her She-Ra form with a sigh. Before she could catch her breath, several sets of arms were around her, pulling her into a warm hug. Mara's heart ached with a tug as she looked to Serenia, Gideon, Nessa, and Lev, taking in first their bright smiles, and then the bags under their eyes, the lines of exhaustion on their foreheads, the tightness of their cheeks, and the visible scrapes on on their skin.

"I-I'm sor--" she began.

"Don't even start with that," Serenia sighed, hugging Mara a little tighter.

"You didn't know this mission would land us in jail," Lev said.

"Beside, i-if anyone's to blame, it's me for not being a better interpreter--" Gideon tried.

"*STOPPPPP*," Nessa sighed. "What is it with you all and saying 'sorry' when a simple 'thank you' is enough."

"Okay, okay," Mara let out a laugh that existed somewhere between a sob and mirth. "*Thank you.* Thank you all for waiting for me, and for fighting so I could let out the other prisoners."

"You're *welcome*," Nessa said with emphasis and her teammates chuckled.

The group lingered together for a long moment before finally pulling away. As Lev settled back on his scooter and the crew dispersed to their seats to man the ship, Mara's gaze fell on the figure of Light Hope hovering nearby. The AI wore a curious expression on her face that Mara found herself mirroring back while she drew nearer.

“What does it mean when everyone is hugging like that?” Light Hope asked.

“They’re all relieved,” Mara tried, struggling for the right words. “Um… gratitude.”

“Why gratitude?” Light Hope asked, the ends of her lips quirked in a smile.

“Because we all missed each other.”

“Missed?” Light Hope asked, wearing a distant expression as she searched her files for meaning. “An emotion?”

“Y-yes,” Mara said. “To miss someone is to… to wish they were there, when they weren’t. Sometimes missing someone is a small thing, like you’re making someone’s favorite sandwich and you wish they were there to try it. In this case, we all were very worried about each other, and we all wished we could be together, even though we couldn’t.”

“Missed each other. Missed…” Light Hope murmured.

“*I-I missed you, Hope,*” against her better judgment, the words tumbled out of Mara’s mouth barely above a whisper.

The AI regarded her with wide eyes and Mara’s face flushed red.

“I-I-I-I mean…” Mara tried.

“You wished I was there?” Light Hope reiterated.

“I-... Y…. yes.”

“Why?” asked the AI.

Mara’s face became even redder. “I… I always wish you were with me,” she said. Then she hastily added, “I-I mean, when we go places. Y-you would love seeing so much of Etheria, and it would be g-great to have you around!”

“Always with you…” Light Hope repeated, her voice distant.

“Y-yeah…” Mara struggled as Serenia shot her a look of pinched lips and arched brows from across the room.

“Then I suppose I missed you as well, Mara,” Light Hope said, her tone showing just a hint of warmth as she smiled and tilted her head.

“Oooooooh~” Serenia squealed from the other end of the room before the rest of the crew burst into laughter.

Mara turned away, covering her face.

“Uh, w-w-where is Shay? I-I need to have a word with them,” she asked as she marched stiffly towards the door to the bay.

“Shay is currently in the storage room,” Light Hope announced with a small beep.

“Storage room?” Mara asked, brows pinching.

“Are they hiding from us?” Nessa asked, her tone flat.

“Probably need time to be away from people,” Lev said.

“Yeah, I guess…” Mara’s tone was dark as she moved out of the cockpit into the hall leading to the bay. As she rounded the corner, she pressed her hand to the button and the storage room doors slid open.

Shay sat in the center of the room amidst the haphazardly stacked boxes. Their head whipped around at the sound of the door opening, body tense before they let out a sigh.

“Oh, it’s just you,” Shay said.

Mara coughed out a huff of shock. “I- Yeah, I mean, it *is* just me, but we have to talk about your behavior back there,” she said.

"Sure, sure, but this first," Shay said, pointing to the weapon they were dismantling atop a set of boxes.

"No, I-- What are you doing to that thing?" Mara asked.

"I had a suspicion about the weapons the Lizardfolk were using," they said. "Remind you of anything?"

"Any similarity to our military's weaponry is easy enough to explain," Mara said. "Laser guns look the same across many cultures."

"Explain this," Shay said, pulling the power unit out from the weapon. The hacker held up the pink, glowing crystal in front of Mara.

Her eyes widened, her mouth fell closed, and a chill ran up her spine.

"It's… powered by our people's technology?" her breath caught in her throat. "H-how did they get these? How? *How*?"

"Three very good questions."

Galena

"Wh… what does this mean?" Mara's voice sounded distant to her own ears as she took the data crystal to examine it more closely.

Shay raised an impatient eyebrow. "You already know what this means," their tone came across so matter-of-factly that it toed the line of condescension.

"I don't! I don't know what this means!" she insisted, panic crawling up her throat to choke her. "M-maybe the Lizardfolk stole it from one of our soldiers-"

"All of Chamelea's royal guards had these weapons, Mara," Shay insisted. "That's a *lot* of soldiers losing a lot of weapons."

"Then they intercepted a shipment!" Mara insisted, her voice pinching with fear.

"Cool thought. I wondered the same, so I looked it up by a part number," Shay said. "These weapons were decommissioned 80 years ago."

Mara opened her mouth, but no sound came out. Her brain screamed nonsense as she held her head, trying to pry free her thoughts from the tangled web.

"Mara…" Shay said her name like a pained parent watching their child struggle through school.

"*No,*" was all that could come out of her mouth.

"No?" Shay repeated, stunned.

"You're wrong," Mara insisted, her eyes gleaming with unshed tears. "And I'm going to find a way to prove it."

Shay went silent. Mara wondered if this was the first time the hacker couldn't summon a sarcastic retort. They shook their head

faintly in Mara's direction, sighing before closing their eyes.

"I hope you're right," they murmured.

In a flash of light, Light Hope's hologram manifested in the middle of the room, partially submerged in boxes. Shay and Mara shrieked, rushing to their feet.

"L-L-Light Hope!" Mara yelped as Shay smushed the weapon into a partially-empty box. "H-hoooow much did you hear?" She tried offering an innocent smile that more closely resembled a grimace as her gaze met Shay's.

Light Hope tilted her head, blinking at Mara. "I hear everything on this ship," Light Hope said simply as Mara felt something deep within her gut sink.

The hologram offered her a kind smile. "I'm happy to inform you that you are ready for your performance review," she said. "In the meantime, the rest of your squadron will be sent to the location that has been scouted for my upgrade. Nessa, Lev and Shay will put together blueprints to build a Watchtower that will connect me to the planetary mainframe. Shall I inform Serenia that she will be in charge of this outing?"

"Y… yes, please," Mara said, her voice tight in her throat as she watched Light Hope blip out of existence.

"She can hear everything…. Oy vey," Shay muttered as they reached into the box to pull the weapon free.

"*Give me that,*" Mara whispered, grabbing at the weapon.

"*Hey, stop, what're you doing?*" Shay whispered back, pulling it free from her hold.

"*I need to show this to the Council to get answers,*" she insisted, reaching for it again.

"*Oh, you are **not** letting the Council know that we know about this,*" Shay responded, holding it up over her head.

"*We need answers, Shay!*" Mara's voice squeaked with frustration as she tried jumping to grab the weapon.

"*You wanna get yourself killed? Fine. But I'm not letting you do it the stupidest way possible,*" Shay retorted before Mara yanked the weapon free. "H-hey!"

"*What do you expect me to do? Be suspicious for the rest of my life?*" Mara asked as she tried opening the power chamber to insert the crystal back into it.

"*No,*" Shay insisted, closing their hand over the power chamber. "*I'm expecting you to use your brain about this. You can't just wave this thing in front of the Council and expect everything to be hunky-dory. You have to be cunning about this, Mara.*"

"*I'm. Not. Cunning,*" she stated, tugging at Shay's fingers.

"Ow! *Yeah, I noticed,*" Shay snapped, shaking their hand free.

Mara closed the power port and turned to leave.

"Stop stop stop stop stop," Shay whined.

"**Whaaaaaat?**" Mara snapped, sounding like a frenzied mother.

"Maybe you don't do cunning, but that's my area of expertise," Shay said, popping open the power cartridge and pulling free the crystal. "Here," they said, holding the pink rock out for Mara. "This is all you'll need."

Mara stared down at the crystal, confusion evident in the knit of her brows.

"Every data crystal has a specific shape according to its function, and this one is a weapon crystal," Shay said. "It has the part number written on the data, see? 'Galena.' Ask the Council -- or,

better yet, someone who *isn't* on the Council -- about this. Just this part. See what they have to say."

She took the crystal in hand, frowning down at it.

"If you don't get the answer you're looking for, we can discuss you bringing the weapon to the Council," Shay reassured her. "Just give my method a try first."

"You promise not to show the weapon off or talk about it to any of the others?" Mara asked.

"Of course," Shay said. "I mean, except Lev. He'd find it *very interesting.*"

"*Nooooo-wuh,*" she said the word so slowly that it transformed into another sound.

"Aw, come on, Lev can keep a secret!" Shay insisted.

"Yeah, Lev's mouth can, but his behavior is going to be different. What if the others figure it out? It'll create too much confusion for everybody if there winds up being a perfectly good reason for all this."

Shay sighed, rolling their eyes. "*Fine…*" they said.

Mara nodded slowly. "Then it's a deal. I'm doing it your way first," her hand closed around the crystal as she handed the weapon back to Shay. "Now… find somewhere to hide this where the others won't find it.

Shay nodded, watching Mara depart. As soon as the door closed behind her, Shay carelessly tossed the unusable weapon into a box across the room with a shrug. "That works."

Grappling

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

While her team worked in the long grass of an empty meadow at the northmost point of the Whispering Woods, Mara sat in awkward silence at the console of her ship as it moved through Etheria's atmosphere. Her free hand was on the keyboard, but her gaze strayed far into the distance, roving over pieces of information made tangible within her imagination. Her other hand lingered in her pocket, tracing over the edges of the weapon's data crystal.

"L… Light Hope?" Mara asked and her constant companion flickered into existence nearby.

"How can I help you, Mara?" Light Hope asked with a cheerful smile and head tilt.

"A while ago, I asked you about She-Ra," she said. "You told me I wasn't the first person to carry the mantle of She-Ra, but then at the same time you said I was the first of my kind."

Light Hope's holographic eyes blinked in confusion. "Wh… what is the root of your query?"

Mara began to pace through the empty cockpit, avoiding the hologram's gaze.

"In training to earn the mantle of She-Ra, I was told stories of what made other She-Ras so… *She-Ra*," she said, letting out a bitter laugh that stung on its way out of her. "I thought maybe I was like them."

She looked up at Light Hope whose gaze darted to the side in confusion before landing back on her. "Mara...?" Light Hope's voice sounded distant.

"But the princesses… some of them knew She-Ra already," Mara went on. "Glacia -- she said I was the Legendary Protector of Etheria. Angella too -- she said there were legends of a princess who awakens at times of great disaster and desperation…"

Her hands moved to her throbbing head as she tried to shake the jumbled thoughts loose.

"I've been so *busy*, pulled in so many directions all the time I haven't had the chance to stop, to think, *why* would Etherians know about She-Ra if we've only been settling the planet for 50 years? And why would they think She-Ra was supposed to protect them if she's an Eternian construct? A-a sword? A piece of technology!" her voice rose as desperation clawed within her.

"I… I cannot answer the root of your query," Light Hope said, her voice growing small.

"*Why?*" Mara's voice pinched with pain.

"It is part of your mission--" Light Hope began as the ship shifted and began to descend.

"Then I should KNOW these things!" Mara insisted. "Deena said I'm made of the same magic as her, but Eternia never had magic. What am I really? What is She-Ra?"

"That data is classified as part of the Heart of Etheria Project--"

"You know about this. You know the truth about this… about me," Mara insisted as the ship shook, settling onto the ground. "And you're *keeping it from me*," her voice cracked as tears welled in her eyes.

"I-"

"**What else are you keeping from me, Hope?**" Mara ground out between her teeth as she squeezed the weapon's data crystal against her palm. The ship's platform slid out onto the grass below. "What are we really doing on this planet?"

“I… Mara, I…” but as Light Hope spoke, a cry of pain echoed through the woods towards them.

Mara’s breath caught in her throat. “Razz--” she gasped, running off her ship and into the woods.

“Mara!” Light Hope cried, her hand hovering after the other woman. As Mara disappeared into the greenery, Light Hope bit her lip, her gaze lingering towards the ground. She closed the outer door with a wave of her hand and powered down the ship.

Heart pounding in her ears, Mara rushed towards the sound as an open field came into view. Catching sight of Razz’s colorful rags, Mara pushed herself between the old lady and the gargantuan boar.

“Watch out!” she cried. “For the honor of Grayskull!” the words slipped from her mouth as the warm energy spread through her, reshaping her and replacing her uncertainty with a sense of competence.

She-Ra’s gaze settled on the enormous beast. Calculations ran through her head before she held her sword aloft, charging at the creature and leaping. Despite She-Ra’s confidence, the boar reared its vast head, knocking She-Ra from the air. She landed on her back, the air leaving her lungs, as the Sword of Protection flew, clattering to the ground several yards away.

"Get up," commanded the spirit of She-Ra within her, and Mara rolled back on her hands, springing onto her feet.

As she rushed towards her sword, the creature charged through her path. She narrowly evaded it with a sloppy half-circle, as she realized with a sinking sensation that her weapon was even further out of her reach.

"Dodge," the She-Ra in her mind commanded her.

I don’t know how! Mara insisted within her own mind. *I’ve never been trained to fight.*

"Then use what you were trained in."

As the boar rushed towards her, Mara tried to envision herself in the training grounds of the space station she called home. The memory Dree Elle's voice awakened in her mind: *"Double back-handsprings, now!"*

Adrenaline pumped through her as Mara followed the instructions, leaping through the air towards a tree to make space between herself and the frenzied creature. Her feet barely touched the bark before Dree Elle's voice came to the surface once more, guided by Mara's adrenaline.

"Twist!" her coach demanded, and Mara deftly twirled out of the tree as the boar rushed to tusk its branches.

Her gaze fell on the old woman who stood as if transfixed by the fight before her. A surge of protectiveness rose within Mara.

"Razz, run!" she commanded the elderly woman with a swift gesture of her arms.

"Mara, no!" Razz cried as the creature gored Mara with its tusk, knocking her to the ground. The wind left Mara's lungs as the confidence of She-Ra became overshadowed by fear and pain. She struggled to unsteady feet as she watched the monstrous creature paw at the ground before charging at her once more.

This is how I die… the thought rose to the surface of her mind as the magic of She-Ra seemed to resonate in sickening agreement.

Chapter End Notes

Hopefully I added something interesting to the already awesome scene of the boar fight from the episode Hero.

Gentle

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Calculations ran through Mara's head as she tried to will her body to keep fighting.

A figure leapt into view, the hunched form of the elderly woman visible and her arms outstretched as she shouted, "STOP!"

For a moment, Mara's heart stopped and her body refused to move. She watched the charging boar slam its hooves into the upturned earth, before it skidded to a halt mere feet from the old lady. The boar took a few shaking steps back as Mara found the strength to climb to her feet.

"It's alllll riiiiight," Razz cooed at the gargantuan monster who growled and wheezed in fear. "Nobody here will hurt you."

Guilt clenched in Mara's stomach as she listened to the creature squeal out a roar of terror while the old woman talked to it like a child with a scraped knee.

A bony hand was on her arm, and in the next moment, Mara felt Razz tug her towards the nose of the beast. The creature stumbled back, unleashing another high-pitched squeal of fear. Yet that didn't deter the old woman, who nodded at Mara to proceed.

Razz let go and for a moment, Mara's hand hung in midair as she stood between the decision to approach, or flee. In the face of the old woman's incredible tenacity, Mara couldn't imagine listening to the fear that bubbled faintly within her.

Mara took that step forward, arm outstretched. The boar, seeming to understand Mara on a level that went beyond words, moved to

meet her touch. Its enormous snout huffed out a puff of warm air at Mara as her hand settled against its skin.

That warmth came alive within their bones, spreading through both figures as the two began to glow. Razz grinned, indicating the creature as a smile broke out on Mara's lips. She moved over to pet the creature's cheek, catching her reflection in its blue eye.

She seemed to be sparkling, glowing in that sky-colored orb. But by contrast, she stood too tall, all sharp edges. She-Ra was a warrior, built for strength and fighting.

With the fear and fight both gone, Mara let the magic of She-Ra recede back into her distant sword. Blinking up once more into the great creature's eye, she saw herself as smaller, curious, with an awkward smile on her lips.

The creature took in the sight of Mara and let out a sigh.

"Go now," Mara reassured the creature. "Be at peace."

The boar turned its mighty head, then nuzzled the woman, grunting happily as Mara giggled and leaned into the touch, hugging his nose. As the boar pulled away, it gave another happy huff before trotting off, as Mara watched with a matching smile on her lips.

Razz's gaze fell on the land, surveying the damage caused by the battle. Mara caught sight of the pain in the older woman's expression: that unique mourning the elderly carried for that which was lost to unsteady memories.

"Razz?" she caught herself murmuring the other woman's name as guilt twisted and stacked within her. "I-I-I'm sorry. I thought it was gonna hurt you." She realized she was making excuses for her behavior, rather than owning it. But as she opened her mouth to offer a proper apology, Razz's pruny hand gave Mara's arm a reassuring squeeze.

“That’s alright, dearie,” she said, sorrow tingeing her words. Then an eager smile spread across her ancient lips. “Come here,” she insisted, tugging Mara down with surprising strength.

“Wh- What are you do--?” Mara began as she struggled to catch her balance, her hand landing on the upturned earth.

The grass shifted beneath her fingers, fluttering as if waving with an energy that came from within her. The familiar warmth of magic flowed from Mara’s form, spreading across the damaged land, enveloping them both in the hot-white comfort. It was the same sensation as the time She-Ra restored Granamyr.

“How am I doing this?” the words escaped Mara’s lips as she watched the plant life return, more abundant than before. Her hands felt so steady against the ground, and the sensation that rose instead of fear was elation. “How is this possible without the sword?”

Razz let out a cackle. “She-Ra is not a sword!” the old woman shrieked as if Mara had just told the funniest joke. “She-Ra is YOU!”

A tingling sensation spread through Mara, as the heat of magic mingled within her, connecting to every fiber of Mara’s body.

“Etheria chose you,” Razz insisted with a wide smile.

An orb of comforting light floated towards Mara. Like the snowflakes the rained down on Sparkle’s northbound ship, Mara found herself reaching for a little fleck of light. But this one didn’t melt and disappear between her hands: instead it granted her a feeling of comfort. The usual doubts and anxiety felt so far out of reach, instead being replaced by a feeling of perfect harmony.

But that was wrong, Mara’s mind insisted from within.

“But *my people* chose me to be She-Ra,” Mara insisted, fighting the urge to blindly accept everything around her. “I need the sword to control She-Ra’s magic,” she insisted.

Her gaze moved to the distant field where her sword rested, a testament against everything she had been taught.

"That's what my superiors always told me," her voice grew weaker as doubt shifted to the surface.

Razz let out an obnoxious laugh. "She-Ra was here long before your people arrived," the old woman insisted. The air left Mara's lungs as she thought of the ancient, She-Ra-shaped temple where she received her orders, the faceless idols inside… "You cannot *control* magic!" Razz said as if the very idea was ludicrous. "Magic simply *is*."

Another delicate orb of light floated towards Mara, which she reached towards without hesitation. Feeling the presence of the magic resting on her fingertips, she tilted her hand to let the tiny fleck of light cascade over her fingers.

A sensation tightened around her chest. When she let out her breath, an overwhelming sense of affection flowed with the air.

"I love Etheria," Mara murmured, feeling more certain of this than anything else in her life. "I love how… old and weird and beautiful it is."

Her gaze moved to Razz. "I'm sworn to protect it as She-Ra, just as I'm sworn to serve my people. But..." Mara said, hesitation in her voice as that momentary confidence faded in favor of sincerity. "I know we're doing something to the planet.

"The Heart of Etheria Project… I don't know all the details, but I know it's big," she went on, aware now of the dangers that came from sharing this information with an Etherian. But she couldn't let these words go unspoken.

As the orb disappeared to mingle with the other strands of light, Mara's hand moved to her pocket, fingers wrapping around the weapon's data crystal. "They say we're the heroes, but I don't know if it's right…"

Razz watched her as if understanding her on a greater level than words could express.

“She-Ra protects Etheria,” Razz said. “Your people made the sword, but they did not make She-Ra.”

Chapter End Notes

> Admittedly, this whole chapter was that one scene in "Hero," but hopefully I was able to flesh out more of Mara's thoughts and feelings to give greater context to the conversation she and Razz had.

Geriatric

"My people made the sword… but didn't make She-Ra…" Mara repeated as Razz took on a distant expression. "They made… the sword. But She-Ra…"

Mara looked up. "Razz, what does that mean exactly?"

Razz blinked her owlish eyes at the other woman. Mara blinked back.

"Ohhhh, Adora! There you are!" Razz cried. "Come, you come help old Razz make soup for Mara."

"Uhhhhhhhh…." Mara's eyebrows rose as she regarded the other woman.

"She's very sick, you know," Razz insisted, nodding.

The hope that filled every inch of Mara now sunk as a pit in her stomach. Why did she think she could trust everything the old woman said? She reminded herself that Razz barely made sense three-quarters of the time, so surely this was another example of that.

Mara stood, moving to retrieve her sword as she frowned down at the gem embedded in the hilt.

"Come, Adora, hurry!" Razz cried. "We need SOUP!"

"Uh… A-another time, Razz," Mara told her as she tried to mask her expression with a smile. "How about I walk you home?"

"Pahhhh, Madame Razz knows how to get home," the old woman insisted. "It's just uhhhhhh. Just uhhhhhhhhh…." she tapped her ancient finger to her chin as she looked in various directions.

Mara approached, holding out her arm which Razz accepted gratefully.

“THAT WAY!” the old woman declared and marched in the wrong direction as Mara followed along.

It took more than an hour to get Razz home, all while the sensations of magic and connection to Etheria faded into a distant memory within Mara’s mind. As she made her way back to the temple, she wondered if all of that was some kind of hallucination brought on by the old woman’s words and the circumstances that threw them into the path of one another.

Yet as her mind filled with doubt, she caught sight of a flicker at the corner of her vision. Looking over, she watched a tiny orb hover at ear-level, as if whispering its secrets to Mara. She raised her hand to catch it, closing her hand around the light until the glow was gone.

“Oh! Sorry!” she yelped as she released the orb, which flickered as if in response. Mara let out an embarrassed chuckle. “I thought you’d go flying away before I could touch you, like snow,” she insisted.

It spun lazy circles and flickered a few more times before turning to float deeper into the forest.

“You don’t look hurt at least,” Mara said as she watched it fade out of sight. Her gaze moved down to her sword.

“She-Ra isn’t a sword…” she murmured, trying to find sense in those words. “Then what are you, She-Ra? If you’re really me, why does it feel like you’re a different person than me? A… a better person than me?”

There was no reply. Setting her sights forward, Mara entered the clearing. She hesitated near the entrance to the temple before pushing herself inside.

She knew the way without the guidance of light, and transformed before she slipped her sword into the slot to awaken the machine.

“Welcome, Mara,” came Light Hope’s voice, and for the first time, Mara was not grateful to hear it. “You’re more than an hour late for your performance review.” the hologram said as she cast her light throughout the room. Mara’s gaze fell to the faceless idols on the platform beside the machinery, their tiaras and pointed shoulder pads glistening.

“Is everything alright?” Light Hope asked, pulling Mara’s attention back to her.

“Put General Sunder on,” Mara said, her tone firm.

Light Hope frowned, her eyebrows pinching. “I will see if he is available.”

The hologram hovered in awkward silence as it processed the request on the other side. While Light Hope tried reaching out to the general, her gaze kept flickering nervously back towards Mara. Mara kept her eyes focused on the ground, avoiding taking in Light Hope’s expression as guilt and resentment both bubbled for dominance inside of her.

The general’s face flickered onto the screen, a polite smile on his lips.

“You had us worried for a little while there!” he admitted before his scarred face returned to its typical strictness. “Is everything alright?”

“Yes sir,” she said, her tone more even and confident than she expected it to be. “There was a disturbance in the forest. An old woman was being attacked by wildlife I… think.”

“Old woman?” he repeated back. “An Etherian? None of them should be near the forest. Did you escort her out?”

“I…” Mara hesitated, reaching into her pocket as her gaze moved off the screen. “I escorted her home.” The words sunk in her throat as guilt won the dominance battle.

“Very good, captain,” he said. “Ensuring the area is clear of any local disturbances was a wise step. We can’t have Etherians listening in on these meetings.”

“Y… yes sir,” she said.

“Before we begin your review, do you have any questions?” he asked.

Silence filled the gaps in the air as Mara’s hand closed around the data crystal.

“A-actually…” she began.

“Hm? What is it, Mara?”

She pulled the crystal from her pocket, gripping it tightly between her fingers.

“Sir, we found this in the possession of elite members of the Lizardfolk kingdom,” she said before biting her lip as she held the data crystal to the screen. “General Sunder, do you know what this is and why it was with them?”

He fell silent for a long moment.

“Yes, yes Mara, I do,” he said. “And it’s time you know more about the Heart of Etheria Project.”

General

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The General stood as if at attention with his hands clasped behind his back, staring a little past the screen as he spoke.

"The Heart of Etheria Project's purpose is to siphon the excess portions of Etheria's magic into a well at the core of the planet," General Sunder said. "All the magic that would normally go to waste is instead recycled into energy there, using the planet's existing functions while assisted by our technology."

Mara expected a chilling revelation to reach her ears. Instead, the explanation sounded perfectly palatable.

"You're recycling magic…?" she repeated back.

"Yes."

"Wh… why?" Mara blinked with her words.

"To create technological advancements that can improve the lives of Etherians for hundreds, if not thousands, of years," General Sunder said simply. "We're trying to provide Etherians an opportunity to enter into the modern world by converting the magical output into energy. By understanding the magic of Etheria and combining it with our technology -- which is no seamless endeavor -- we open the doors to massive growth in medicine and space travel that will put Etheria on the map."

"This sounds… amazing," Mara admitted with a shaking laugh. "But why all the secrets?"

"None of our attempts found success, until recently," the general said. "Plus we can't have the local Etherians or people of other worlds catching word and interfering with the tests. We're taking a

great deal of care to learn as much as we can about Etherian magic. It exists in contrast to everything we know about technology, so merging the two is difficult."

His scars tightened at the slightest hint of a smile and General Sunder looked Mara in the eye for the first time.

"But your team has proven it isn't impossible," he said. "It seems She-Ra is the key to uniting the two different aspects."

"M-me?" Mara repeated as she felt warm magic rush through her transformed body like adrenaline.

"The Salineas Sea Gate you and your team so expertly created has changed the course of our research," General Sunder said, tilting his chin at her as if acknowledging a superior officer.

"That was all Shay and Lev's hard work a-and Gideon, Nessa and Serenia putting in the labor. Oh! And Prince Aquanis and the Salineans!" she insisted. "I-I didn't do much of anything."

"You are the key that connects Etheria's magic to Eternian technology," he insisted. "You should be proud of everything you've done. Without you, this project would have failed."

A feeling like pride welled within Mara, but settled sourly in her stomach.

"That leads me to my review," the general went on, and Mara noted that he put on his best business tone. "You fixed the disrupted runestones in both the Kingdom of Bright Moon and Salineas. You solved both problems creatively and in a way that has opened Bright Moon to working with other nations for the first time in hundreds of years. Salineans have returned to their homes and Bright Moon is helping with the rebuilding efforts."

"Oh, that's wonderful!" Mara gasped. Her thoughts strayed to Angella and her face grew warm as she imagined the princess interacting with Prince Aquanis.

“Full marks. You’ve done valiantly,” Sunder said. “Your next mission brought you to the Kingdom of Snows, in which Corporal Romeo reported the peace arrangements did not go smoothly,” he said. Mara winced.

“However, by removing Princess Chamelea, and ending the use of that port, the Kingdom of Snows has begun finding other ways of making trade with the rest of Etheria,” Sunder went on. “Princess Glacia is working out a peace treaty with Princess Fae so that the Silaxians may travel unbothered through the Valley of the Lost. In return, the Forest Elves get first pick on all trades. The Kingdom of Scorpion Hill, which is on the other side of Etheria, has not interfered.”

Mara bit her lip. “So… so that’s a good thing.”

“And you brought back the last surviving dragon to his homeland,” Sunder added. “That was… completely unexpected. None of that mission went the way we predicted. We’re still not sure what to make of all these changes. But… we can’t deny that the outcome is optimistic.”

Mara nodded eagerly. General Sunder met her gaze and something flickered in his expression as he studied her hopeful expression. His eyes focused past her.

“There have been pitfalls, struggles, and changes with worldwide consequences,” he said. “You’ve given hope to Etherians and helped restore balance, which you already know is your main purpose. But you’ve also changed the course of several kingdoms permanently, and dissolved one entirely.”

She watched him, feeling desperation climb within her as she fought back the urge to apologize.

“Your next mission is to negotiate a land dispute at the Kingdom of the Meadowlands,” Sunder explained. “The native Bovidae kingdom is being threatened by the presence of an itinerant

Magicat colony. Both groups are claiming the runestone as rightfully theirs.

"Make contact with Princess Heifinia, sort out the territorial feud, and prevent war from happening," he said. "I've sent Light Hope the necessary coordinates."

"I'll do my best, sir," she said, giving him an Eternian salute.

His eyebrows pinched as he looked her over. "Please don't let us down," he murmured. "Etheria is counting on you."

Pain crept through Mara, starting at her chest as she fought back the urge to cry.

"I-I won't…" she murmured.

The screen disappeared, leaving the room an endless pit of darkness. Mara clutched the data crystal in her pocket and wondered bitterly what the point of questioning him about this was.

"All I did was make him doubt me…" she murmured, slipping out of her She-Ra form.

As she boarded her ship, Light Hope flickered into existence with a soft "Mara." Eyebrows pinched, the hologram studied Mara with a look that matched the pain and humiliation of the other woman.

Mara couldn't summon the words to respond.

"Mara, what does it mean when a person lies to you?" Light Hope asked. "Why do they lie?"

"I…" Mara searched her mind, trying to remember a time she could have lied to Light Hope. "I-I don't think I've ever been dishonest with you, Hope."

"No, Mara, I do not believe you have misled me at any time," Light Hope confirmed. "But I believe General Sunder was lying."

Chapter End Notes

Yes, Mara is terrible with confrontation.

And for those who haven't seen the word before, a siphon is a device that pulls water from a filled area through a series of pipes. Siphon off is a term we use to describe taking a portion of a liquid through that pipe system. I used the word to give you an idea of what that technology looks like at the Heart of Etheria.

Update 1/15/22:
I changed "invading" to itinerant regarding the Magicats. The explanation is in the notes at the end of the next chapter.

Gap

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“Lying to me?” Mara repeated back, her voice tight in her throat. “A-about what?”

“I am uncertain,” Light Hope responded. “However, he gave several body language cues that he was possibly deceitful. This will require further research.”

Mara nodded slowly, unease settling over her like a damp blanket.

“Then… please do so, Light Hope,” the words came unsteadily out of Mara’s mouth as she stared past the hologram, through the windshield of the cockpit. Colorful clouds floated past them as the moons slowly shifted alignment.

The hologram of Light Hope opened her mouth to say something to fill the silence. But the words never came. She lowered her gaze to the floor as the two sat in uneasy silence.

The ship began to shake as it approached its landing. Tall stalks of wild grass rustled into view as the platform slid open to the side.

Cheers and hoots of success met Mara’s ears as her team boarded the ship.

“Finally, flat surface!” Lev exclaimed as his scooter climbed up the ramp.

“Just once I’d like to see them send us somewhere *actually* scooter accessible,” Shay muttered.

Nessa followed closely behind, quirking an eyebrow towards Mara. “You gotta see the model we made for this thing,” she said. “It’s

going to be *complicated.*" Despite her words, she had a hard time hiding a widening grin.

"I'll get started on making something for us to eat," Gideon said, rubbing his hands together with a warm smile.

Serenia was the last one up, standing tall with pride, her shoulders squared back.

"Mara," she said and there was such confidence in her voice that Mara found herself clinging to the other woman's words. "The mission was extremely successful. How was your review?"

Mara's own words didn't come as easily. "G-good…" she said, finding herself breathless with the lie. "Can we… can we talk..?"

"Somewhere private? Sure," Serenia finished for her and looked around. "We're alone here."

Both Mara and Serenia's gazes moved towards the hologram of Light Hope who looked between them, blinked, then disappeared.

Serenia shrugged. "I mean, alone as we can be with an AI always watching us."

Mara lowered her gaze and hugged her arms as a chill ran through her.

"You're not okay," Serenia said simply and lowered her voice. "What did he say?"

"Do you ever think…" Mara began, "that maybe She-Ra should have gone to you?"

Serenia rolled her eyes, turning away. "Not this again. It's been months since you've had these kinds of thoughts."

"But it's true," Mara insisted. "You surpassed me in all the tests and training. There's no reason for them to pick me over you."

"But they *did*," Serenia said, moving to rest her hands on either side of Mara's neck, her thumbs gently brushing the other woman's cheeks as she tilted Mara's gaze to meet hers.

"They saw something in you that went beyond anything some stupid test could determine," Serenia went on. "And honestly, if it's anything like what I see in you, then they definitely made the right choice."

Mara let out a shaking breath. "H-how are you so sure?"

"Because when I lead from the heart, it gets me into conflict, and then I don't know when to stop," Serenia said. "But when you lead from the heart? You connect with people. Every. Single. Time."

Mara trembled in Serenia's hold as a tear slid down her cheek.

"But I failed Princess Glacia a-and Princess Chamelea, the Silaxians and the Lizardfolk, and--"

"Hey," Serenia's voice became soothing as she wiped the streak away. "You see the good in every person. And because of that, you give them a chance to be their best. Not everyone's going to take that opportunity, but I'm sure they'll remember your kindness."

An unsteady smile spread across Mara's lips as she took in the other woman's words.

"I wish I knew how to be as certain of things as you are," Mara said.

"Well, then I guess that's why you keep me around," Serenia teased, tapping on the end of Mara's nose playfully.

The giggle that escaped Mara's lips faded quickly.

"I saw something… something that gave me a lot of doubt," Mara began. "Doubt about our people, our mission, our… whole purpose on this planet."

Serenia’s eyes widened and for the first time, Mara witnessed a childlike curiosity spread across the other woman’s face.

“It made you doubt that much?” Serenia asked, her voice distant.

Mara nodded. “I’m sure it was all a misunderstanding,” she insisted. “But if I show you, maybe I can borrow some of your certainty and get some answers.”

Serenia opened her mouth to reply, but Mara spoke up.

“The thing I have to show you, it’s something that upsets you,” Mara said. “I just want you aware before I bring it out.”

Serenia clenched her hands into fists. “Ok,” she whispered. “I’m ready.”

Chapter End Notes

> This took so long because the following chapter was tangled up in my head so badly. I really started fighting myself about the length this detour might take, but then I realized I'm in control of how long this story ultimately is. So... it doesn't matter if it's over 100 chapters I guess!

Grimace

Mara pulled the data crystal from her pocket and Serenia winced reflexively.

"A data crystal? Jeeze, you scared me!" Serenia's relieved voice carried a laugh as she held her hand out for it.

"It… it goes to… a weapon," Mara murmured as she handed the tech to her second-in-command. "A.. a laser gun."

Imbued with that information, the data crystal seemed heavier in Serenia's palm.

"You mean the weapons the Lizardfolk had?" Serenia's tone was tight and low, reverberating through her chest.

Mara's eyebrows pinched. "You knew?" her voice grew soft.

"I recognize an Eternian weapon on sight, yeah," Serenia muttered, her hand closing over the data disk. "I knew it couldn't be a coincidence that some Etherians had this kind of technology, but...." she scoffed from the back of her throat and looked away.

"I thought… maybe it meant our presence on this planet was a danger to everyone," Mara said, her words carefully chosen and slow. "That maybe the deaths of the dragons, the war between the Kingdom of Snows and the Kingdom of Scorpion Hill -- that it was all our fault. That *we're* responsible for all these disasters going back 50 years."

Serenia's eyes widened on Mara. She stared at her captain as though she'd never seen her before.

"*We're* not responsible for all of that," Serenia insisted, her voice rising. "The *Eternians* are."

"*We're* Eternians, Serenia," Mara pleaded with her. "We may not be from their planet, but they're our people."

“No, they’re not,” Serenia snapped. “And they never will be.” Mara watched Serenia’s eyes brim with flares of darkness like fading embers, amidst unshed tears.

“You… you know I can’t see it that way,” Mara murmured, lowering her gaze. “Even though I’m seeing a lot of dangerous things coming together, I don’t think we caused this harm on purpose.”

“Yeah,” a harsh scoff escaped from the back of Serenia’s throat before she clamped down on the emotions that boiled over inside her. “Sorry,” she admitted. “I just… I’ve never seen you show doubt about the Council’s decisions like this before.”

Serenia let out an unsteady chuckle that was more rough edges than mirth as she handed the data disk back. As her hands met Mara’s, their fingers entwined.

“You usually reserve all your doubt so you can direct it at yourself,” Serenia pointed out with a raised eyebrow.

Mara’s words died on her tongue as she struggled to argue against, then ultimately agree with, Serenia’s stinging words. “I…” she faltered. The ship rattled as it initiated its descent.

Light Hope blipped into existence before them. “We are now entering the Kingdom of the Meadowlands,” the hologram informed them, her gaze flickering down to stare at Mara and Serenia’s clasped hands, before Light Hope disappeared once more.

Mara nodded, her words floating somewhere beyond the region of her mouth.

“It’s okay,” Serenia insisted, jostling Mara with her elbow affectionately.

Mara sighed, tilting her head to rest on Serenia’s shoulder. “You’re right though: I do doubt myself a lot, don’t I?” Mara asked.

“Yup, every chance you get,” Serenia said.

“Every time something goes wrong, I… I think it’s because of me,” Mara said. “I-I think… I think I would rather it be my fault, you know? If it’s my fault, then maybe I can fix it. Or… or if it’s so bad that I can’t, then maybe I can just… live with it.”

“You don’t want to consider that there are people out there who don’t care about others half as much as you do,” Serenia said, giving Mara’s hand a little squeeze. “It’s… something beautiful about you. But it’s painful to watch, too.”

“I-I’m sorry,” Mara murmured, her breath tightening in her chest. “I-I’ll try to work on it.”

Serenia’s smile slipped from her face and she found her gaze too heavy to lift.

“I love you exactly the way you are, even though it hurts to see how you treat yourself,” Serenia said. “I’d love to see you be a little more selfish, but…” she shrugged. “I don’t want you pushing yourself just to make me happy.”

“I-” Mara’s thought was disrupted as the ship settled on the grassy plains, its ramp sliding out to meet the dirt below.

-

They arrived on the outskirts of the Meadowlands, the ship disguising itself as a boulder. Mara wondered why they bothered hiding when so many kingdoms already knew of their arrival. Her mind snagged on all the secrets, all the hidden things throughout the planet that were kept from the very people who lived here.

She moved through grassy plains with her team in toe, past modest homes made of dried grass, straw, and mud. Satyrs, minotaurs, and other hooved humanoids moved through the area, treading stone pathways as they hung laundry, traded supplies, and talked cheerily to one another. Yet they all fell silent and stopped moving once they caught sight of Mara and her team.

A tingle of discomfort moved through each of the Grayskull Squadron as they felt the eyes of dozens of inhabitants follow their every move.

They approached a home that sat in the center of the meadow. Made entirely of stone, it was neither taller nor more ornate than the other plain homes.

“Is this really where a princess lives?” Nessa was the first to speak up, her eyebrow raised in doubt.

Gideon nodded and a nervous smile flickered on his lips. But before he could open his mouth, an enormous horned figure approached from inside.

“Mara,” the stranger spoke with a soothing voice, despite towering over the team. She held a sleeping baby in her arms as she offered an exhausted smile down at them. “We’ve been expecting you. I’m Princess Heifinia.”

Gamut

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

It took a long moment for Mara's eyes to adjust to the darkness inside of the stone building. Heifina sat in a wide earthen chair built into the far wall of the narrow home, her sleeping baby tucked in her arms. The candles flickered, their glow absorbed by the inky walls, as they sat surrounding a jagged black stone at the center of the room.

Mara's gaze connected with the stone and she felt a tingle like electricity run through her nerves. The room seemed to grow darker for a brief moment, before her night vision kicked in.

"This land is threatened by powerful enemies through the use of dark magic," Heifinia began, her voice barely above a murmur, though her tone carried hardened edges. "Their twisted magic has compromised this kingdom's runestone, the Eclipse Peak."

She gestured towards the stone at the center of the room. The light of the flickering candles betrayed the lines of sorrow and exhaustion on her face.

"How is that possible?" Nessa spoke up, her voice wavering.

"Well, *that's* not good," Shay muttered. Lev shushed them.

"For thousands of years, this kingdom has been built through the geokinesis that the Eclipse Peak provides," Heifina said, pain wrinkling her brow. "We use it to work with the land to provide my people shelter, safety, and privacy. But these villains manipulate the Eclipse Peak for a darker purpose."

"P… Princess Heifinia," Mara began, stepping forward. "I am so sorry that someone is manipulating your runestone. Do you know what their goal is?"

Even in the dim candlelight, Mara watched Heifinia's gaze sharpen. A ripple of anxiety ran through the leader of the Grayskull Squadron's shoulders and she took an unconscious step back.

"They've made it clear that they intend to take this kingdom for themselves, force my people out of their homes, and dethrone me," she said. "They think their twisted connection to the Eclipse Peak is proof enough that it belongs to them. Bright Moon found them guilty, and sent them to their own island so they would not harm the runestone again."

Mara hugged her arms, struggling for words. Serenia stepped forward, speaking up.

"Do you know the identities of these invaders?" she asked, meeting Heifinia's hardened gaze.

"Of course I do," the princess said with a bow of her horned head. "The Magicat colony. They live on the outskirts of our society, always moving so our scouts have trouble locating them."

Serenia and Mara met one another's gaze. Mara turned to the rest of her crew.

"Any names?" Lev asked. "We might be able to find their last location if we can get names."

Heifinia nodded as she took in a slow breath.

"Clawdeen is the name of their false princess," she said. "I don't know the rest of them, but if you can find Clawdeen, you can stop the Magicats' takeover."

"They're nomadic, right?" Gideon asked. "Do you know where the last campsite was?"

Heifinia nodded. "The last sighting was 50,000 steps southeast from here," she said as she rose to her feet. She looked down at the much shorter Grayskull Squadron and blinked. "Or… probably

56,000 steps for you. Your red-haired friend may be the exception," she said, nodding her head towards Gideon who grinned in response.

–

The Grayskull Squadron returned to their ship and flew 25 miles southwest, overlooking the area that Heifinia designated as the Magicats' encampment. The land below was green and clear from any signs of life.

"I am detecting punctures in the ground that could have been used for installing tents," Light Hope said.

"It's worth investigating," Mara said with a nod. "If we study the land, maybe it can help us find where they moved to after this."

The ship settled into the open meadow, lowering its ramp to the uneven dirt. Lev's scooter made it to the bottom of the ramp before giving up, so he delicately hobbled on his crutches until he found a hole to sit near.

"Light Hope was right," Nessa spoke up as her datapad scanned the area. "These holes were definitely made for wooden posts, using a very specific tool."

"Very Specific Tool," Shay murmured. "That's my new band name."

Lev snickered.

"The tool was…" Nessa began. "I mean… it's called a post hole digger, I don't know what to tell you."

Shay snorted aloud, their partner rapidly following suit as the two stared at Nessa with eyes wide in disbelief.

"No way," Lev chuckled.

"Wow, that's the least creative name I've ever heard – you come up with it yourself?" Shay teased.

“Shudd***ap!***” Nessa snapped.

There was a rustling from off to the far side, where the meadows shifted to barren but gloomy woods.

“Did you guys hear that?” Mara asked, a chill climbing up her spine. Walking hesitantly towards the beginning of the woods, her foot snagged on something small and made of cloth.

“How can I hear anything over *these two* and their **non-stop commentary**?” Nessa demanded.

“Ohohooookay everybody,” Gideon began, holding up his hands to placate Nessa as he put too much effort into relaxing every line of his face. “Why don’t we all take a deeeeeeeeeeep breath–?”

Mara bent down to pick up the object: a dirty ragdoll, with little brown triangles where its ears should have been.

There came another rustle and a high-pitched giggle. Serenia’s head snapped in the direction of the sound, but the woods were too dark to peer into.

“I heard it too… Mara, whatever you do, don’t–”

A tiny figure, or an animal covered in a hooded cloak rushed on all fours towards them, emitting a high-pitched growl, its tail batting in all directions.

“What the–?” Mara’s thoughts were disrupted as the diminutive figure head-butted her in the stomach, expelling all the air from Mara’s lungs and forcing her back to meet the craggy, uneven ground.

Chapter End Notes

HAPPY HOLIDAYS I FINALLY POSTED.

Heifina's name is based on the word "heiffer" meaning a juvenile female cow, though this is obviously a grown woman.

The Isle of Purrsia is a reference to the original series, where Catra claims to come from.

The Eclipse Peak is a Black Tourmaline gemstone.

Update 1/15/2022:

Hey guys, upon analyzing this storyline and getting input, I found that the way I had written it came across as Pro-Israel, which was never my intention. While I want the Magicats to reflect both Arabic and Jewish experiences, including the experiences of Palestinians, I never meant for the story to sound supportive of any of Israel's current policies. Because of that, I have gone back and rewritten portions of the story to erase elements of a "return to the homeland," I changed it so the Magicats have never actually left the Meadowlands, and I changed aspects to make the situation a little bit more generic. I'm sorry for the mistake I've made, which was an oversight on my part, and I appreciate the people who helped me correct this.

Gumption

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The tiny figure wrapped her arms around Mara's neck and as the hood fell aside, Mara caught sight of a child with catlike features and untamed hair. The child beamed a toothy grin at her and let out an immense purr as her hold around Mara's neck softened to a hug.

"I CAUGHT ONE, I CAUGHT ONE!" the tiny figure cheered, rubbing her cheek against Mara's chin as the Greyskull Squadron hurried to Mara's side.

"Pawshminaaaa, stoppppp," another figure of a similar diminutive size whined as she trotted the same path as the other on two legs.

"Did Mom see? Did Mama see? I caught one!" the child called Pawshmina asked, her tail curling in delight.

A giggle escaped Mara's lips, and she reached under her back to pull free the dirty ragdoll.

"Is this yours?" Mara asked with a smile as she held it up to Pawshmina.

"Oooooh that's Purrveen's dolly!" Pawshmina screeched, pointing at the girl who looked so much like her.

Purveen hugged her arms and tried to bury her face deeper in her cloak.

"Purveen, use your manners!" Pawshmina insisted with a grin.

"*You're gonna get us in trouble*," Purrveen hissed from between clenched teeth.

“What’s going on over here?” there came a voice that carried an air of authority from the woods as two taller figures emerged. They walked elegantly on two legs, their hoods betraying lumps where pointed feline ears were covered.

“I think I’ve been captured,” Mara said with a laugh.

“I *caught* one, Mom!” Pawshmina insisted, wiggling in joy.

“You certainly did, dear,” the one called Mom replied. “It’s a matter of *who* you caught, now isn’t it?”

“Mamaaa, I tried to stop her,” Purrveen whined, gripping at the robes of the other taller figure.

“We know, sweetie,” the one called Mama said, petting the top of Purrveen’s head and purring softly.

Crouching down, the one called Mom wrapped her arms around Pawshmina’s middle and pulled the wriggling child up off of Mara. Her hood fell free, revealing a mass of delicate curls, each reflecting red in the sunlight, and a wide grin connected to tired eyes.

“Don’t let her escape!” Pawshmina squealed, pointing at Mara.

“Ohh, I’m not going anywhere,” Mara said with a chuckle before the woman called Mama extended a hand to her.

“At least let us help you to your feet,” Mama said, her eyes glowing faintly beneath the hood as a soft smile rested on her face.

While the rest of the Greyskull Squadron hovered uselessly nearby, Gideon showed no hint of shyness as he approached Mama, holding out his hand for her to shake. After Mara was safely to her feet, Mama returned the gesture with gratitude widening the boundaries of her smile.

“I’m Gideon,” he said.

“Furjah,” the one called Mama said. She gestured to the other woman. “This is my wife, Clawfika. Sorry for the trouble from our little ones.”

“No trouble at all,” Mara insisted, smiling towards Pawshmina who let out a massive yawn, exposing rows of pointy teeth. “Can… I ask what brought you here?”

“Ah,” Furjah indicated the ragdoll in Mara’s hand.

“R-right!” Mara let out a nervous chuckle. Kneeling before the shyer child, she held the doll out to her. “Your name is Purrveen, right? Is this doll yours?”

Purrveen hid behind Clawfika’s legs, peering around them to watch Mara with wide, suspicious eyes that glowed faintly beneath the hood.

“It’s ok,” Clawfika encouraged her. Purrveen looked towards Furjah, who nodded in agreement.

Purrveen pulled back her hand and snatched the doll from Mara’s grasp, scampering several steps away.

“*Purrveen, manners,*” Clawfika insisted.

“Yeah, Purrveen, *manners!*” Pawshmina teased with a laugh.

“It’s alright, she’s scared,” Furjah murmured, then turned to Mara and her team. “Sorry about that. Purrveen isn’t used to strangers. Our community is very tight-knit and we don’t interact much with people outside of it.”

“I can relate: I’m a little nervous too,” Mara said, shifting to her feet as she smiled at the shy girl.

Purrveen parted her lips on a hiss, and made a beeline for Furjah.

“What brings you to this area?” Clawfika asked, her voice strong. “Are you travelers? Your transportation looks befitting of those

always on the move.”

Mara glanced back towards the undisguised ship and winced.

“O-oh, y-yeah,” she murmured.

“We’re looking for someone,” Serenia spoke up. “A person by the name of Clawdeen. Have you heard of her?”

Clawfika and Furjah exchanged looks as the smiles slipped from their faces.

“You’re speaking of our princess,” Furjah murmured as Purrveen clung to her robes once more.

“We heard she was a *false* princess,” Serenia said between gritted teeth.

“Is that what they’re saying these days?” Clawkfika asked, her tone betraying a bitter chuckle. “I would expect no less from the Bovidae kingdom – or even Heifinia herself.”

Serenia struggled to hold back a nasty retort.

“Then…” Mara began, stepping between them as she pleaded with Clawfika, “please teach us about what this situation actually entails. We only know what Heifinia said, and our job is to help settle your princess’ conflict with her.”

Clawfika scoffed, but spoke. “Fine. Come with us, and we’ll show you the truth about our kingdom,” she said. “But keep up.”

The group began moving forward, but hesitated.

“Hey uhhhhh any chance we can offer them a ride instead?” asked Lev as he hobbled towards his scooter.

Chapter End Notes

> Happy holidays and a happy new year! Thank you to those who have been reading all along!

Galavant

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

“BUTTONS!” Pawshmina shrieked, running haphazardly around the cockpit as she tried to touch everything within sight. Both of her moms followed her closely, trying to deflect her hands until Clawfika found herself in an impromptu sparring match.

Light Hope flickered into existence in the cockpit, and Purrveen released a scream in response to her appearance.

“A GHOST!” Purrveen cried before bursting into tears.

“Mara, why have you brought native Etherians onto the ship?” Light Hope asked as she watched Furjah rush to comfort her crying child. Pawshmina, meanwhile, rushed up to Light Hope and kept sticking her hands through the holographic construct, which fizzled in response.

“I-I wasn’t about to make them walk all the way to their camp,” Mara tried to sound self-assured, while the weight of her mistake settled onto her shoulders.

“Ghost lady ghost lady ghost lady,” Pawshmina started chanting as Purrveen wailed and the harried mothers tried to wrangle their overexcited children.

Nessa stood from her station and Mara tensed, sensing that things were about to take an even worse turn. As the engineer marched past Mara’s seat, Shay let out a quiet “Oooooh someone’s in trouble.”

“Pawshmina, right?” Nessa asked, kneeling next to her. “You feel the faint buzzing on your fingertips when you touch the hologram? That’s because she’s made of hard light.”

"*Hard* light, hard *light*," Pawshmina began chanting as Nessa went into a description of the tech that created Light Hope. As she spoke, she made direct eye contact with Gideon, and nodded towards the wailing Purrveen.

Gideon stood from his station, a warm smile on his lips as he approached Furjah.

"Can I pick her up?" he asked.

"You can try," Furjah sighed.

Gideon lifted Purrveen into his arms and began humming, gently rocking her. The small girl, too old for lullabies, nonetheless quieted down in his arms. Purrveen wrapped her arms around his neck, clutching him close as Furjah let a relieved smile slip out.

"*Don't let the ghost lady get me,*" Purrveen hissed between gritted teeth.

"I'll make sure she doesn't, but I don't think she wants to get you," Gideon said. "In fact, I think she's a little scared of you."

Light Hope floated just out of reach of Pawshmina who squealed and continued trying to grab at her as Nessa went into further detail about the technological components. Her holographic lips were pulled back in a sneer of discomfort as she squirmed and hovered away.

"She's definitely scared of your sister," Gideon admitted.

Purrveen let out a breathy chuckle and ducked her head behind Gideon's shoulder.

"*Most monsters are scared of Pawshmina,*" the quieter twin whispered.

"That's good to know."

“Well, that’s boring,” Shay sighed, leaning their head back against their entwined fingers. “I thought somebody was going to get in trouble.”

“You’re about to get in trouble if you don’t make yourself useful,” Nessa muttered, glaring daggers into Shay as Pawshmina cackled in delight. Shay spun around in their chair with a raised eyebrow, silently challenging Nessa.

“So this is an Eternian ship,” Clawfika said as she finally looked through the windshield to the rapidly passing land. “It’s space-faring, yes?”

All eyes were on Mara.

“Y… yes,” Mara said. “We’re from a different world and my team and I travelled here using this ship.”

“I want nothing more than to have a ship like this,” Clawfika murmured, her hands clenching, claws extending.

Silence fell over the room. Furjah moved over to grasp Clawfika’s hand, massaging her fingers gently until the claws retracted.

“If we could just leave this world, all of our problems would be over,” Clawkfika insisted.

“I know,” Furjah murmured.

“There’s still hope,” Mara kept her voice low as she tried to bring a sense of optimism. “We don’t understand your circumstances yet but you shouldn’t have to leave your home.”

Clawfika’s yellow eyes glared at the other woman and Furjah stepped between them.

“We have no place, no land, to call home anymore,” Furjah said as the ship shuddered to a slow descent.

“There’s nothing in this world that belongs to my people, except for that runestone,” Clawkfika said.

“Is it really *your* runestone?” Serenia muttered.

Mara hugged her arms as Serenia’s gaze bore into the Magicat mothers.

The ship rattled and then went still as it landed. As the platform slid out, Furjah went to gather her children and Clawfika moved to exit.

Mara grasped Clawfika by the wrist. The Magicat tensed, fur bristling as she locked eyes with the other woman.

“We want to understand,” Mara insisted.

“Do you? Or do you want to pass judgment on my princess and my people?” Clawfika snapped.

“I’m sorry. W-we just…” Mara began.

“I will show you the truth of my people,” Clawfika said. “It’s up to you whether your eyes will be open enough to understand.”

Chapter End Notes

Update 1/15/22:

I edited a few details that needed to be changed for the new canon of the Magicat storyline. The explanation is in the notes at the bottom of Chapter 16.

The original version of Chapter 19 has been deleted since it detailed the illnesses the Magicats suffered from by living in Purrsia. Because the new canon has it so that they never lived in Purrsia, I felt it was best to delete it. I'm sorry if this causes any confusion.

Gala

Chapter Notes

> Thank you all so much for your patience. An explanation of delay is at the bottom of the chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

"Aw, we missed the wedding!" Pawshmina cried, puffing out her cheeks in frustration. It was several paces before the music caught up to the Grayskull Squadron's ears. "Come on, they're already dancing without us!" The child tugged at Nessa's hand, brushing past Serenia and Mara in her effort to drag her new friend to the front of the line.

Mara's boots sunk into pathways carved in mud as her gaze lingered on the sparse, weather-worn canvas tents that sat atop rusting poles. Lev's scooter whirred and growled as it maneuvered over clods of dirt and rocks. He murmured reassurances to it and patted its handlebar.

The tent flaps parted to reveal a gathering of dozens of people dancing, singing, and swaying. With few instruments, the crowd of Magicats clapped out beats and harmonized their voices to fill in the melodies. Many wore cloaks over their heads, the outlines of their ears poking out from beneath the cover, as children raced around the crowd, playing a game of tag with one another.

The scents of almonds and honey clung like a sweet film to Mara's tongue as sets of glowing yellow, blue and green eyes turned towards the newcomers, tails flicking behind their figures with interest and agitation. The movement stopped, the laughter fading, as a silent exchange happened between Clawfika, Furjah, and the gathered crowd. Mara looked between them, watching the gentle shift in body language, the tension in their tails, the twitches of their lips.

With a sigh of relief, the music started up again and various spicy-scented foods on trays were carried towards the visitors. The air was filled with aromas Mara had never encountered while living on the space station: the scent alone seemed to awaken her pulse, and as she observed her team, she saw her smile was matched with theirs.

Then a hand grasped hers and yanked her forward. Stumbling, Mara bumped into a Magicat in a long blue dress with intricate patterns beaded across it.

"Visitors, for my wedding!" the bride cried with musical delight in her voice as her yellow eyes lit with delight. "This is everything I dreamed of."

"O-oh, th-thank you?" Mara stuttered as she stumbled after the woman who shifted her hand to entwine with Mara's, leading her into a line. Another hand connected with hers and Mara turned to catch sight of Serenia being led by a woman in a matching yellow dress, with blue eyes.

The dancers began stomping to the beat of the music, tapping a pattern forward and back that Mara struggled to keep up with. Every time she caught the rhythm, they shifted to a kick and she started over. Despite her confusion, the line began moving until it formed a circle, legs crossing over one another with each step.

The stomping of their spinning circle grew faster as the dancers switched to skipping, then hopping backwards, the bride pulling Mara to quicken her pace as she helplessly tugged the other bride along. In a flurry of gossamer fabric, the participants' feet barely touched the ground as they glided gracefully with each kick, while Mara and Serenia struggled to match their tempo. Mara's hand tightened on the beautifully dressed woman's, who turned to smile back at her.

As Mara caught herself wondering if this girl was the princess, her grasp fell away as the dancers broke apart to trot to the rhythms. Mara weaved around the others as she stumbled, trying to avoid

being in their way but finding herself in the paths of several people. Finally a hand on her arm yanked her back and a peal of laughter escaped Mara's mouth as she recognized Serenia as her savior.

"I think that was the princess," Mara said, her voice taking on an airy quality as she fought to catch her breath.

"What? Why do you think that?" Serenia asked, her gaze darting towards the two mothers they had shuttled to their destination.

"I… I don't know. It's just a feeling," Mara insisted. "I felt like I *knew* her already, you know? Where are the others?"

Serenia pointed to Lev and Shay who were hovering by one of the many food tables, with Shay politely shaking their head to decline the offer of a dance from a polite Magicat, and Lev laughing along. She pointed to Nessa who was chasing one of the children. As soon as her hands grasped Pawshmina's hood, she lifted the little girl into the air, who squealed in delight, and they hugged one another with a deep familiarity.

"Gideon's of course trying to learn everything about their culture from our hosts," Serenia added, her tone dry as she pointed to the man, whose cheeks matched his red hair as he giddily took notes on something that Furjah was lecturing him about.

"This… this place, these people," Mara began. "It feels… *right,* somehow. Like I've been here before. I can't explain it."

"... It reminds me of home…" Serenia admitted, her tone low. "Before the Eternians took us away from Primus, this is what our weddings, our parties, our little moments of joy felt like. It was just a group of people surviving together, but it was *warm* and *familiar*, and like every moment was worth celebrating."

Mara focused her gaze on Serenia.

"Do you really think the princess of these people stole power from the Eclipse Peak with some kind of dark magic?" she asked.

Serenia pressed her lips into a thin line.

“I don’t know what to think anymore,” she admitted, her hand moving to her forehead to push away a loose strand of dark hair. “Heifinia felt cold, distant, possessive. But these people are so warm, inviting, and generous. But that doesn’t mean Heifinia’s suddenly the villain just because she’s intense.”

“Yeah,” Mara murmured, lowering her gaze.

“And if Clawdeen did use dark magic, the kindness of her people doesn’t absolve her of that crime, even if I’m finding the whole story harder to believe now,” Serenia admitted.

“Clawdeen didn’t use dark magic,” came a voice from nearby. The two tensed as they matched gazes with Clawfika’s yellow, piercing eyes. “And I can prove it.”

Chapter End Notes

> Sorry for the delay! I know it’s been a while since I’ve updated. I’ve spent the last two months studying representation, Palestinian culture, and what counts as cultural appropriation. I’ve learned a lot and I’m finally feeling more confident about this next portion of the story.
>
> It was my goal to try to incorporate a little bit of Palestinian culture into the story of the Magicats. However, what I found along the way is that it’s impossible to incorporate just a little bit of another culture, because cultures are so rich, with so much history, religion, practices, etc. I can’t simply take the few elements that I have and go “that’s representation,” so I won’t even pretend that is the case. This isn’t representation. It’s a nod to a culture that I have only the tiniest connection by blood to, and had little knowledge of before these last few months.
>
> The Magicats’ dance is based on this.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!